

# THE AI TOOLS STACK 2026

Every Tool I Use, When, Why, and What It Replaces

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## My Daily Tools

| TOOL        | USE CASE                                   | COST            | REPLACES        |
|-------------|--------------------------------------------|-----------------|-----------------|
| Claude Code | All coding — apps, APIs, debugging         | \$20/mo         | \$5K+ dev       |
| n8n         | All automation — leads, content, invoicing | \$0 self-hosted | \$200/mo Zapier |

## Weekly / Monthly

| TOOL        | USE CASE                              | COST    |
|-------------|---------------------------------------|---------|
| Perplexity  | Deep research before projects         | \$20/mo |
| ElevenLabs  | Voice content for reels               | \$5/mo  |
| Midjourney  | Branding, thumbnails                  | \$10/mo |
| GoHighLevel | CRM, funnels, email, SMS — all-in-one | \$97/mo |

## Claude Code vs ChatGPT vs Cursor

| SCENARIO                      | WINNER           | WHY                               |
|-------------------------------|------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Full app from scratch         | Claude Code      | Reads entire codebase, multi-file |
| Quick snippets / explanations | ChatGPT          | Fast, broad knowledge             |
| Editing existing files in IDE | Cursor           | Inline suggestions in VS Code     |
| Complex debugging             | Claude Code      | Traces through actual code        |
| Content / copy writing        | ChatGPT / Claude | Both excellent                    |

## n8n vs Zapier

| FEATURE | N8N | ZAPIER |
|---------|-----|--------|
|---------|-----|--------|

|              |                             |                      |
|--------------|-----------------------------|----------------------|
| Price        | \$0 unlimited (self-host)   | \$20-\$200+/mo       |
| AI nodes     | Built-in GPT/Claude/Gemini  | Limited              |
| Custom code  | Full JS/Python              | Limited              |
| Self-hosting | Yes — your data stays yours | No                   |
| Ease of use  | Medium (worth it)           | Easy (for beginners) |

## 60-Day "Learn AI" Roadmap

| WEEK | FOCUS       | GOAL                                |
|------|-------------|-------------------------------------|
| 1    | Prompting   | Master Claude + ChatGPT             |
| 2    | Automation  | Build 1 real n8n workflow           |
| 3    | Vibe coding | Build + deploy 1 web app            |
| 4    | AI agents   | Build 1 chatbot with your data      |
| 5-6  | Combine     | Full system (app + automation + AI) |
| 7-8  | Freelance   | Sell 1 automation for \$500+        |

## Free Alternatives Cheatsheet

| PAID TOOL    | COST     | FREE ALTERNATIVE           |
|--------------|----------|----------------------------|
| Zapier       | \$200/mo | n8n (self-hosted)          |
| Mailchimp    | \$80/mo  | Resend (3K emails/mo free) |
| Heroku       | \$25/mo  | Vercel / Railway free tier |
| Airtable     | \$20/mo  | Supabase / NocoDB          |
| Calendly Pro | \$12/mo  | Cal.com (open source)      |
| TOTAL        | \$337/mo | \$0/mo                     |